



Check Calls & Tracking

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 13 of 18 · Running the Load · about a 13-minute read

Marcus picked up clean Tuesday and he's rolling to Dallas, so you move on to the next thing. You don't call, you don't check — the load's handling itself, right? Then Thursday at 1:15, your phone rings. It's Smith Logistics, and they're not happy: the receiver just called *them*, because the truck never showed for its one o'clock appointment. Marcus is stuck three hours back — he hit a highway closure outside Shreveport that morning, and you had no idea. The appointment's blown, the receiver's annoyed, the broker is quietly deciding whether to ever use you again, and there is nothing you can do now but apologize.

Here's the part that should sting: that delay was knowable *hours* earlier.

A load you're not watching is a load that surprises you — and in this business, surprises cost appointments, money, and the one thing that's hardest to win back: the broker's trust. A dispatcher watching the load catches that closure at the morning check call, and goes to work on it while there's still time.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Keep tabs on a load from pickup to delivery: run check calls on a rhythm that fits the load, always know where the truck is and whether it'll make its appointment, and keep the broker informed before they ever have to ask. The goal isn't busywork — it's to see trouble coming early enough that you can still do something about it.

1 Why You Watch the Load

The moment the truck is rolling, your job changes from *setting the load up* to *watching it run*. And watching has one real purpose: **early warning**. A problem you catch early — the truck's falling behind, the driver's low on hours, there's weather ahead — is a problem you can still act on. The exact same problem, discovered when the truck doesn't show at the dock, isn't a problem you can solve anymore; it's just a failure you have to report.

There's a second reason, and it's about your reputation. The broker has their own customer asking where the freight is. The dispatcher who keeps them in the loop is one they trust and call again; the one who goes silent until something blows up is one they replace. So from pickup to delivery, you stay on the load. Two tools do it: **check calls**, and **tracking**.

2 Check Calls: the Rhythm of Knowing

A check call is exactly what it sounds like: a quick call or message to the driver to confirm where he is and that everything's on track. It's how you *know* the load is fine instead of *assuming* it. The skill is running them on a sensible rhythm:

- 1 **After pickup.** Confirm he's loaded and rolling (you saw this in dispatching).
- 2 **During the run.** At least once on the way; on a multi-day load, a check first thing each morning is the habit, because it tells you whether the day starts on schedule.
- 3 **Approaching delivery.** Confirm he's on time for the appointment, so you can give the broker a clean heads-up.

Match the rhythm to the load: a tight, critical, or high-value run gets watched more closely; an easy one with cushion gets a lighter touch. And keep the calls efficient and respectful — the driver's working, and he shouldn't be fumbling with a phone while he's driving. Quick, clear, and scheduled when you can. What you're confirming each time is simple: where are you, are you on schedule for the appointment, are hours and fuel okay, anything brewing I should know about?

3 Tracking: Knowing Where the Truck Is

Calling is one half; tracking is the other — actually following the truck's location and progress rather than only hearing about it. Tracking can be a tracking app on the driver's phone, the truck's GPS or ELD, location updates the driver sends, or — more and more common — a tracking app the *broker* requires that shares the truck's position with them automatically.

Whatever the method, here's the number that matters: the truck's **ETA** — its estimated time of arrival — measured against the **appointment**. Tracking is one constant comparison: given where he is right now and the miles and hours left, does he get there on time? That's the question you're always answering. "I think he's fine" becomes "*I can see he's forty miles out and on time*" — and the difference between those two is whether you'll be surprised.

HONOR A TRACKING REQUIREMENT

Many brokers now *require* you to accept tracking for the load, and it's often written right on the rate confirmation. Honor it. Going dark or refusing tracking is one of the fastest ways to look like a problem carrier.

4 Keeping the Broker Informed

Now turn that information outward. The broker needs to know status because their customer is asking them — and the dispatcher who tells them *before they have to chase you* is the one who gets the next load.

Update proactively. Confirm the pickup, give a status on a long run, and the moment anything threatens the appointment, say so. Don't wait to be asked.

Get ahead of bad news — this is the big one. If the truck is going to be late, the broker needs to hear it from you *as early as you know*, so they have time to manage their receiver. A heads-up at nine in the morning is a manageable problem. A no-show at one o'clock is a disaster with your name on it. Same delay — completely different outcome, decided entirely by when you spoke up.

Not watching — surprised at 1:15	Watching — caught at 9:00 AM
The receiver calls the broker when the truck no-shows	You call the broker first , before they ever ask
Appointment already blown — nothing left to do	Hours of runway — there's still time to work it
Broker quietly decides not to use you again	Broker learns you're a carrier they never have to wonder about
All you can do is apologize	You manage the problem instead of reporting a failure

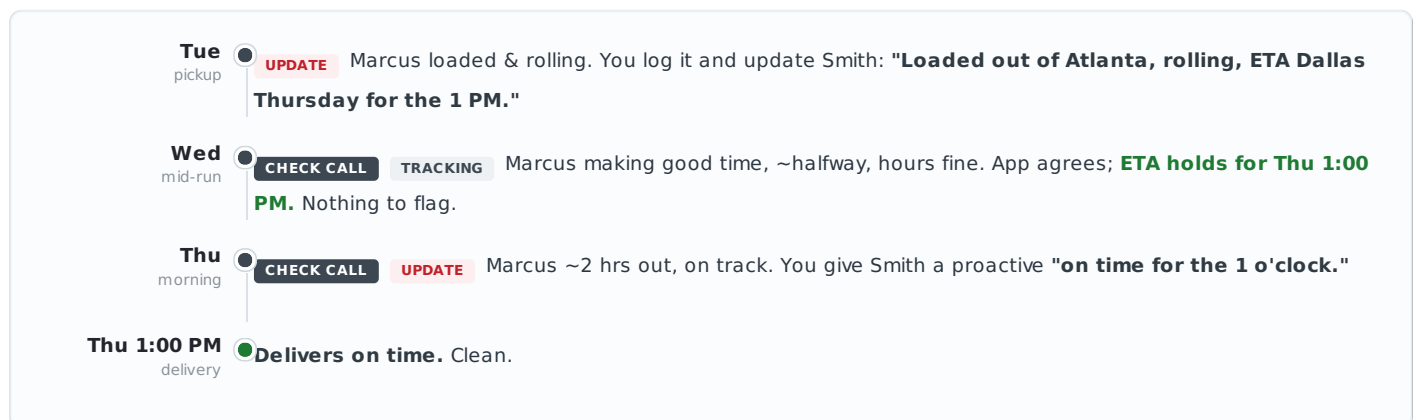
5 Spotting Problems Early — and What Comes Next

Pull it together, because this is the entire point of watching the load. You run the check calls and you track the truck so you can **catch the early warning signs**: the truck slipping behind its ETA, the driver running short on hours, weather or a closure on the route ahead, a reload running long, or — a quiet red flag — the driver suddenly going silent. When you spot one of these, the early catch *buys you options*.

But notice the line we're drawing: *spotting* the problem early and *solving* it are two different skills. Catching it is what this lesson is about — notice it, and don't sit on it. Actually working the fix — reworking the appointment, finding a reroute, handling a breakdown or a detention that's spiraling — is its own playbook, and it's exactly where we go next. For now, lock in the discipline: a problem you see coming at nine in the morning is a problem you can still solve; the same problem at the appointment is just an apology.

Walkthrough — Watching Marcus to Dallas

Picks up right after dispatch (anchor: Atlanta → Dallas, Thursday 1:00 PM appointment). First the load watched properly — then the same load where the early catch pays off.



THE SAME LOAD — WHERE THE EARLY CATCH PAYS OFF

THU 9 AM Morning check call → Marcus reports a closure; he's running **~3 hrs behind**.

BECAUSE

You called at 9 AM, you catch it with **hours of runway**. You immediately flag Smith: "*Heads-up, closure outside Shreveport, looking at ~4 PM, not 1.*"

Now there's TIME to work it. (How you work it = the next lesson.) Same driver, same closure as the opening story — the only thing that changed is that you *were watching*.

The 9 AM check call is what turned a 1:15 disaster into a manageable morning heads-up. You didn't fix the closure; you just refused to be surprised by it, and that bought everyone time.

Module 13 Glossary — your quick reference

The two tools for keeping eyes on a moving load.

Watching the load

Check call	A quick call or message to the driver to confirm his location and that he's on schedule — how you know the load is fine instead of assuming it.
Tracking (load tracking)	Following the truck's location and progress — via a phone app, GPS/ELD, driver updates, or a broker-required app — so you can compare its ETA to the appointment.
ETA	Estimated time of arrival — the truck's projected arrival, the number you constantly measure against the appointment time.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. What is a check call, and why do you run them?
2. How should you set the rhythm of check calls on a multi-day load?
3. When you track a load, what's the key thing you're comparing?
4. The truck will be three hours late. When do you tell the broker?
5. The moment you spot the truck falling behind, what's your job in this lesson?

ANSWERS

1. A quick status call or message to the driver confirming his location and that he's on schedule. You run them to *know* the load is on track instead of assuming — and to catch problems early.
2. A sensible rhythm matched to the load — after pickup, at least once during the run (a morning check each day is the habit), and approaching delivery; closer watch for tight or critical loads, lighter for easy ones. No single magic number.
3. The truck's ETA / current position against the appointment time — will it arrive on time given the miles and hours left?
4. As early as you know — immediately and proactively — so they can manage their receiver. Never let them discover a no-show; an early heads-up is manageable, a surprise is a disaster.
5. Catch it early and flag it immediately — the early catch buys time to act. Actually working the fix (reroute, reworking the appointment, handling a breakdown) is the next lesson.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 14: WHEN THINGS GO WRONG IN TRANSIT

Watching the load is how you catch trouble early — but catching it is only half the job. Sooner or later, a load doesn't go to plan: the truck breaks down, weather shuts a route, a delay eats into the appointment, a facility holds the driver for hours. Knowing how to respond — fast, and in the right order — is what separates a dispatcher who keeps the load alive from one who just delivers bad news. You've learned to see it coming; next, you learn what to do about it.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches monitoring a moving load as a generic skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — its check-call cadence and SOP by load type (how often, when, what to confirm); its tracking tools and who watches the board; its broker-update expectations and any message templates; its escalation thresholds (how far behind, or what conditions, trigger a call to the broker and to a lead); how check calls and ETAs are logged in its system; and its policy on accepting broker-required tracking. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*